0-DAU Diagnosis & Activation Decision

10k Athletics — Player App, Regis Pilot Cohort

Owner: Blake Wellington · Status: Decided, roadmap reordered · Last updated: April 2026

TL;DR

Player app DAU sat at zero for the first stretch of the Regis pilot. The instinctive read was that we needed retention mechanics (a leaderboard was the obvious candidate) and the instinctive build was to ship one.

We didn't ship it. Primary research with the pilot cohort showed the problem wasn't retention — players weren't returning because they had never activated in the first place. Adding gamification to an unactivated app would have created a ghost-town effect and obscured the real signal.

Decision: defer the leaderboard, define an explicit activation event, and reorder the roadmap to remove friction in the path to that event. The leaderboard isn't dead; it's deferred until activation is no longer the bottleneck.

Problem

The player app launched to the Regis men's and women's soccer pilot cohort. Sign-ups were live and growing — coaches were inviting players, players were creating accounts, the funnel was visibly working at the top.

Daily active users sat at zero for the first stretch.

The temptation in this situation is to read DAU as a retention number and reach for retention tools — leaderboards, streaks, push notifications, social proof. That framing was wrong, and the cost of acting on it before checking would have been ~2 weeks of engineering on a feature that solved a problem the product didn't yet have.

The Easy Wrong Answer

First instinct: build a leaderboard. The reasoning had surface plausibility — student-athletes are competitive, peer comparison is a known retention lever in fitness apps, the engineering scope was contained. Two weeks of work, ship it, watch DAU climb.

Three reasons that would have been wrong:

- **Wrong problem.** A leaderboard solves "users come back less than they should." Our problem was "users haven't come back at all." Different shape, different fix.
- **Ghost-town effect.** A leaderboard with no entries on it is worse than no leaderboard at all. It signals abandonment to the few users who would have engaged. Building it before activation works means we'd be debugging two problems at once.
- **Signal contamination.** If we shipped gamification and DAU moved, we wouldn't know whether the underlying product had improved or whether we'd just papered over the diagnostic. The instrumented version of the same fix is much easier to read when the noise floor is low.

The decision was to spend the next week on research before any code shipped.

Research

Three methods, deliberately layered. None of them in isolation would have been enough; together they triangulated the same finding.

Method	What it surfaced best	What it missed
Structured survey to the pilot cohort	Breadth: which pieces of the product had been touched at all, which had not.	Why. Surveys tell you what; they don't tell you what was going on in the user's head when they decided not to come back.
Live onboarding sessions with coaches	Friction. Watching them sign up in real time surfaced points of confusion in seconds that no survey would have caught.	Self-selection. Coaches are not players. Their friction points overlap with players' but aren't identical.
1:1 conversations with players	Why. Honest answers about what would have to be true for them to open the app tomorrow morning.	Sample size. ~8 conversations. Enough for thematic saturation, not enough for quantitative claims.

Two methodological choices worth naming:

- **1:1 not focus group.** Group settings reliably suppress honest feedback, especially with a population (student-athletes) where the social cost of saying "I forgot about it" in front of teammates is non-trivial.
- **Future-tense framing.** The most useful question turned out to be "what would have to be true for you to open this app tomorrow morning?" Past-tense "why didn't you use it" produces defensiveness; future-tense produces design requirements.

Findings

Three themes from the research, in rough order of frequency:

Theme 1: First session ended without a moment of value

Players signed up, walked through onboarding, and landed on a dashboard that looked like a to-do list rather than a product. Nothing in the first session communicated why they would want to be there a second time. The most common version of this in interviews was a shrug — not active rejection, just absence of a reason to return.

Theme 2: The IDP wasn't legible at first contact

The Individual Development Plan is the core of the product — the thing that makes 10k different from a generic training app. But on first open, it looked like a static list of generic drills. The personalization (which is the whole point) wasn't visible until a coach had assigned content, and in many cases coaches hadn't gotten that far yet.

The order of operations was inverted: we asked players to trust the IDP before any coach had given them a reason to.

Theme 3: No expectation of cadence

Players had no model in their head for how often they were supposed to open the app. Not daily, not weekly, not "when assigned" — nothing. In the absence of a cadence cue, the default was zero. This is the actual mechanism behind the 0-DAU number; it isn't apathy, it's the absence of a contract.

None of these is solved by a leaderboard. All of them are solved by a tighter, more deliberate first session and a clearer hand-off from coach to player.

Options Considered

Option	Summary	Why not (or: why)
A. Ship the leaderboard	The original instinct. Add peer comparison and competitive mechanics to drive return visits.	Wrong problem. Solves retention, not activation. Risks signal contamination on whatever fix actually works.
B. Push notifications + streaks	Lighter retention play. Nudge players back without committing to a full social mechanic.	Same fundamental issue as A, plus we'd be nudging users back to an app that hadn't given them a reason to be there in the first place. Annoying, not effective.
C. Fix activation; defer everything else	Define an explicit activation event, instrument it, and reorder the roadmap to remove friction along that path. Leaderboard, streaks, notifications all wait.	Recommended. Solves the actual problem, keeps the diagnostic clean, and most retention features are cheaper to build well once we know what the activated user looks like.
D. Pause the pilot, rebuild onboarding from scratch	Treat the launch as a beta failure, take the app down for the cohort, ship a v2 onboarding.	Overcorrection. The product isn't broken — the first session is. Pulling the app would burn coach trust at the moment we most need to keep it.

Decision

Adopt Option C. Specifically:

- **Define the activation event.** "Player opens the app, completes onboarding, and sees their first IDP populated with at least one coach-assigned item." The coach-assigned piece is what makes this distinct from a hollow walkthrough — it's the moment the IDP becomes legible as personalized.
- **Reorder the roadmap.** Anything that doesn't move a player closer to that activation event drops in priority. Leaderboard moves out of the next sprint. Coach assignment flow and first-IDP rendering move in.
- **Instrument before iterating.** Activation rate becomes the headline metric until further notice. DAU stays on the dashboard but is treated as a lagging indicator that won't move until activation does.

- **Re-open the leaderboard question after activation works.** Trigger: activation rate above 50% in the pilot. At that point retention mechanics are solving a problem we actually have.

What Changed in the Roadmap

Item	Before	After
Leaderboard	Next sprint	Deferred. Trigger: activation rate >50%.
Coach "assign first item" flow	Backlog, unscheduled	Promoted to current sprint. Single biggest lever on activation per Theme 2.
Player onboarding	Considered "done"	Reopened. New goal: end onboarding inside the IDP, not on a dashboard.
Headline metric	DAU	Activation rate. DAU demoted to lagging indicator.
Push notifications	Planned for retention push	Deferred. Reconsider after activation works; design intent will be different at that point.

Open Questions / Honest Tensions

- **Is this activation event strong enough?** "Sees their first IDP" is mostly passive — the player has been shown something, not done something. A stronger activation event would require an action (mark a drill complete, log a session). The argument for the current definition is that the IDP being populated is the first non-trivial signal of value, and getting players to that point is the bottleneck. The argument against is that activation events that don't include a user action tend to over-count. Worth revisiting after 30 days of data.
- **Sample size on the 1:1s.** ~8 players is enough for thematic saturation but not for confident segmentation. If the men's and women's cohorts have different friction profiles, this round of research won't have caught it.
- **The coach is the actual bottleneck.** Theme 2 implies the player's activation is gated on the coach assigning content. That makes the coach onboarding flow more important than it currently looks in the roadmap. Open question: do we treat coach activation as a separate metric, or fold it into the player activation funnel?
- **When does the leaderboard come back?** Trigger is activation rate >50%, but that number was set by intuition, not analysis. Worth tightening once we have a few weeks of activation data to anchor on.

Process Learnings

Worth writing down because the same trap will appear again on the next ambiguous metric:

- **DAU is a vague signal.** It can mean retention is broken, activation is broken, the funnel above the app is broken, or the cohort is wrong. Reaching for the obvious lever (gamification) before disambiguating is the most common product mistake.
- **Sitting with zero numbers for a week is the work.** The instinct to build is loudest when the dashboard is empty. The right response to an empty dashboard is usually research, not code.
- **Future-tense interview questions outperform past-tense.** "What would have to be true for you to open this tomorrow" produced design requirements. "Why didn't you open it" produced defensiveness. Worth defaulting to going forward.
- **Triangulate methods.** Survey, observation, and interview each surfaced different signal. Any one of them in isolation would have pointed somewhere slightly wrong.